The Dianalogues

By Laurel Haines

DIANA IMPERSONATOR: **(Pg 59 +)** Every once in a while, I need to take a drag on a cigarette and remember who I am. I swear to God, if one more person tries to kiss my hand, I think I'll scream. I shouldn't complain. It's a good living. It's just that I get in the middle of these parties with everybody wanting something from me, and wanting me to be something I'm not, and it used to be fun, but now it just tires me out. Jesus. I can't stop talking in this stupid accent. Bleah!

INTRODUCTION

*Not **ALL** fairy tales end "happily ever after." Especially not if you are an aging Princess Diana impersonator struggling to make ends meet in the Big Apple. But life is about to get a little stranger for our damsel in distress. As she leaves her late-night gig, she hails a cab driven by Candy, another New Yorker a bit obsessed by the 20th century fairytale life and death of Princess Di. Well, maybe **obsessed** isn't exactly the right word . . . because Candy has a few problems of her own. It's time to meet the ladies!*

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DIANA IMPERSONATOR: You know what just happened in there? I got propositioned. They think I'm a hooker. I guess they think if I'm willing to dress up like this I'll do anything. He was a short man. Kept trying to jump up and grab my tiara. So, I had to get out of there. He wanted me to go home with him and play Royal Court. Believe me, there was a time when I would have taken him up on it. In leaner years. But I've gotten rich off this gig. I couldn't stop, even if I wanted to. I can't do anything else. Oh, I can act, but nobody wants me to do that anymore.

I mean, really. . . Sometimes I look in the mirror and I'm not sure what I see. I've played this woman every weekend for the past eighteen years. I think I might play her for the rest of my life. I walk like her, I talk like her, I dress like her. I have more of her clothes than my

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own. Of course, someday I'll get too old to play her. That's the problem with impersonating someone who's dead. You change while they stay the same.

I don't know what I'll do when this is over. I figure I have another five, ten years in me. Dead icons are the best business. Marilyn, Elvis, you wouldn't believe it, but Nixon is a big one. I heard about a woman in Bel Air who will hire six or seven Nixons at a time, just for herself. Don't ask. I guess I could go back to temping. *(shudders.)* Or telemarketing. I'll still have her voice. Maybe there's a 900 number that would hire me. *(breathy and British.)* Oh, yes, baby, you really move me, you make me feel so wild, so unrepressed, so Scandinavian. *(back to normal voice)* And then I'll take out my dentures.

You know what they should do? They should make an old folks home just for us. So people can come and laugh at us as we get old. Sure, I'm sure there's some freaks out there who would want to see what Diana would have looked like at seventy. Or James Dean at ninety. Not to mention anyone who still thinks Elvis is alive. There's probably weirdos who would take care of us for free. They can come and feed us creamed corn and push us around in our golden wheelchairs. *(She is half-laughing, half-crying.)* Oh God, that's sick.

TRANSITION

In this scene, a cab driver, CANDY, believes that her passenger is none other than Princess Diana, and offers some marital advice.

CANDY: Where to? Around? Lady, I don't just drive around, I ain't a sightseeing tour, you know what I'm saying? This is a cab. I go from here to there, I don't just... *(turns back to audience holding a wad of bills.)* OK, you got it. I'll drive you around. *(drives)*

You from out of town or something? *(pause)* OK, not the talkative type. You know, you really don't need to wear those sunglasses, my windows are tinted. Only people I know who wear sunglasses indoors are movie stars and my Uncle Rick. He got an eye shot out. Hey, wait a minute, you are a movie star! I know I've seen you before. Wait, wait, don't tell me. Melanie Griffith! No? OK, give me another chance. You're not a porn star, are you? Holy

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shit! I know who you are! You're Princess Diana! Holy shit! I've got Princess Diana in my cab! *(turns fully around in her excitement)* What the hell are you doing here? Huh? *(faces forward and jerks the wheel)* Hey! Watch where you're going! Oh my God. OK, OK, I'm cool. Princess Diana! *(listens)* Yeah, sure you're not. I know Princess Diana when I see her, and you're her. OK, fine, you want to pretend like you're not who you are, that's cool. I can do that. I won't say another word. *(silence)*

So, like, what, you just wanna get out of the castle for a while, see a few sights? Figured you'd come to New York for some action? *(pointing)* Bet you don't see freaks like that at Buckingham Palace, do ya? OK, OK, I'll stop. I know what it's like for you royalty, always getting bugged by people. You probably just want some time alone. Hey, that's what's going on! You wanna get away from that husband of yours. Yeah, it's been all over the news. He's having an affair with that lady, whatsername, Camilla! Calling her on the phone and shit. Oh man, let me just say he must have his head up his ass. I mean, she is one ugly bitch! And you, you're beautiful, and glamorous. You're like, a princess! Hey, you're not thinking about getting back at him, are you? I mean, that's not why you're cruising around, is it? Because there are some real weirdos in New York; you should be careful who you pick up. Some guys look real nice, but they're psycho. The Wall Street types especially. It's always the clean-cut looking guys who turn out to have bodies in their refrigerators. I won't pick' em up. And in this part of town, forget about it. Drug dealers and whores, that's all you got on this street. Hey, wait a minute, that's my cousin Denise! Denise!

(turning her head, she nearly runs into a truck and slams on the brakes) Whoa! That was a close one. What were we talking about? Oh yeah, I mean, what guy gives up a princess for some butt-ugly broad? But you know something, it don't surprise me. I mean, men will *(gestures.)* you know, anything that moves. You got to keep your eye on them. I got a lot of experience with that. My guy, James, when we first met he was like, oh Candy, I love you, you're so beautiful, you're my queen, right? And every day, he's going on about how gorgeous I am, and how I should be a model, and I'm like, yeah, you're beautiful too, James. And he's like, no baby, I got my face burned in a fire, I ain't beautiful, and I'm like, yeah, but

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James, you're beautiful inside. And he's like, no Candy, no, you, you're beautiful, you are, you, you are beautiful. And I'm like, OK, I'm beautiful. So we move in together, and we're in love, and we decide we're gonna get married as soon as I can get a divorce from my last husband. Well you can guess the rest of the story. One day, I come home from work, walk in the door, and he's on the floor with the deaf-mute girl from the dry cleaners. And she is a dog. I mean, worse than Parker-Bowles. This woman's face looks like scrambled eggs. And I'm so confused. Because I thought I was supposed to be so beautiful, and here he's been banging a circus freak. And he's like, *(as James)* oh baby, I'm sorry, I don't know what happened, please forgive me, and I'm like, oh no, no you don't. *(as James)* But baby, baby, I can explain. *(as herself)* Oh no, baby. I can explain. And I got my knife and - huh? Oh no, I didn't kill him. I just cut him up a little. Not a lot, just to scare him. That's what you gotta do with men, scare them. He don't fool around no more. *(beat)* That's what you gotta do with your husband. Just cut him a little. I bet he won't be expecting it from you. That's what'll make it twice as good. Dontcha think? Yeah, like one time when the two of you are eating your tea and crumpets and shit, and he gets up to make another phone call, you just go chk chk chk *(makes a stabbing gesture)* He won't be making no more phone calls after that, believe me!

(horn honk.) Oh, go screw yourself! *(to the passenger)* Huh? You wanna get out here? Oh no, you don't. This is not a good area of town. Believe me, you don't want to be walking around here at night, especially a gal like you. They'll eat you alive. No. I'm sorry. I can't let you out. I cannot be responsible for your certain rape and death. Or worse, one of these pimps might decide he likes you. "Princess Diana found turning tricks on Avenue C." No way. That's not gonna be on my shoulders. Well, yeah, by law I have to let you out wherever you want, but that don't mean I'm gonna. Yeah, you paid me. It's your ride. OK. OK, I'll let you out on one condition. You gotta take this. *(holds out a knife)* For protection. And whatever else you wanna use it for. Come on, take it. Yeah, there you go. *(passenger exits the cab -- to herself)* Jesus. *(rolls down her window.)* Hey, good luck, you know? I'm rooting for ya!

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